The Indus Valley Civilisation

Introduction to the Indus Valley Civilisation

The Indus Valley Civilisation, also called the Harappan Civilisation, was one of the world's earliest urban civilisations, along with Mesopotamia and ancient Egypt. It flourished in the north-western part of the Indian subcontinent, in what is now Pakistan and north-western India, in the basins of the Indus River and the now-dry Ghaggar-Hakra river. It belonged to the Bronze Age. The civilisation covered an area of well over a million square kilometres, larger than Egypt or Mesopotamia, and had more than a thousand known settlements. Archaeologists divide its history into an early phase from about 3300 to 2600 BCE, a mature phase from about 2600 to 1900 BCE, and a late phase from about 1900 to 1300 BCE.

Around When Did the Civilisation Flourish?

The Indus Valley Civilisation flourished mainly between about 2600 BCE and 1900 BCE, which is its mature or urban phase, around 4,500 to 4,600 years ago. Its beginnings go back to about 3300 BCE. After 1900 BCE the cities declined and were gradually abandoned, and by about 1300 BCE the urban way of life had largely ended.

Discovery

The civilisation was unknown until the 1920s. In 1921 Daya Ram Sahni of the Archaeological Survey of India began excavating Harappa in the Punjab region of present-day Pakistan, and in 1922 R. D. Banerji started excavations at Mohenjo-daro in Sindh. In September 1924, Sir John Marshall, the Director General of the Archaeological Survey of India, announced the discovery of a new civilisation to the world. The civilisation is called Harappan because Harappa was the first site discovered. Since then, excavations by Mortimer Wheeler, S. R. Rao, B. B. Lal, R. S. Bisht and others have uncovered many more sites.

Name Two Major Indus Valley Cities

Two major cities of the Indus Valley Civilisation are Harappa and Mohenjo-daro. Harappa lies on the Ravi river in Punjab province, Pakistan, and Mohenjo-daro, whose name means "Mound of the Dead", lies in Sindh province, Pakistan, on the Indus. Mohenjo-daro had the famous Great Bath and Harappa had large granaries. Major sites in India include Dholavira in Kutch, Gujarat, which was inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in July 2021, Lothal in Gujarat with its dockyard, Kalibangan in Rajasthan with ploughed fields and fire altars, Rakhigarhi in Haryana, one of the largest sites, and Banawali in Haryana. Other sites include Chanhudaro, Ganweriwala and Surkotada.

Town Planning

The Harappan cities were remarkably well planned. Many had a citadel on a raised platform to the west, which housed important public buildings, and a lower town to the east where people lived. Streets were laid out in a grid pattern, intersecting at right angles. Houses were built of standardised baked or mud bricks with a ratio of 1:2:4, and many had their own wells, bathrooms and courtyards, and some had two storeys. The Great Bath at Mohenjo-daro, a large waterproofed tank about 12 metres long, was probably used for ritual bathing. Granaries stored grain.

What Was Special About Their Drainage System?

The drainage system of the Indus Valley cities was one of the most advanced of the ancient world. Almost every house had a bathroom and a toilet, and waste water flowed through pipes and channels into covered drains running along the main streets. The drains were built of finely fitted baked bricks, sealed with mortar and sometimes lime and gypsum, and they were covered with bricks or stone slabs that could be removed for cleaning. Manholes and sump pits (soak pits) were provided at intervals to collect solid waste so that the drains did not get blocked. Smaller drains from the houses joined the larger street drains, which carried the water outside the city. This careful planning shows a high level of civic sense and public hygiene, with a municipal authority to maintain it. Such sophisticated sanitation was not seen again in many parts of the world until Roman times. Dholavira had an extraordinary system of reservoirs, channels and dams for conserving water in a dry region.

Economy, Trade and Crafts

The Harappans practised agriculture, growing wheat, barley, peas, sesame and cotton, which they were among the first in the world to cultivate, and they domesticated cattle, buffalo, sheep and goats. They made pottery, beads of carnelian and agate, copper and bronze tools, jewellery of gold and shell, and bronze figures such as the Dancing Girl of Mohenjo-daro. Steatite seals carved with animals such as the unicorn bull and the so-called Pashupati seal were used in trade, and they bore the Indus script, which is still undeciphered. The Harappans used standardised weights and measures. They traded with Mesopotamia, which called the region Meluhha, by land and sea, and Lothal had a large dockyard for ships.

Religion, Society and Decline

No palaces or grand temples have been clearly identified, and little is known of the government. Evidence suggests worship of a mother goddess, a male deity, animals and trees, and a sacred bath. Burial was common, with pots and ornaments placed in graves. The causes of decline are debated: possible reasons include climate change and weakened monsoons, the drying up of the Ghaggar-Hakra river, floods, shifts in river courses, a decline in trade and perhaps disease. The invasion theory is now largely rejected.

Tamil Nadu Connection and Recent Interest

Researchers have noted similarities between some Indus signs and graffiti marks on pottery found in Tamil Nadu, for example at Keeladi near Madurai and Adichanallur, and some scholars suggest a link with the Dravidian languages, though this is not proved. Excavations at Keeladi in Sivaganga district, which began in 2014, have revealed an urban settlement of the Sangam age dating to about the sixth century BCE. In January 2025, as the centenary of the discovery of the civilisation was being marked, the Tamil Nadu government announced a prize of one million US dollars for anyone who can decipher the Indus script. The ASI and the Archaeological Survey of Pakistan continue research.

Challenges and Future

The script remains undeciphered, and many sites are threatened by erosion, salt, floods and encroachment. Modern techniques such as DNA analysis, satellite imaging and isotope studies are giving new insights into the people, diet, trade and migration of the Harappans.

Quick Facts

- The Indus Valley Civilisation flourished around 2600 to 1900 BCE in its mature phase.
- Major cities were Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira, Lothal and Kalibangan.
- The cities had covered drains, soak pits, grid streets and standardised baked bricks.
- Sir John Marshall announced the discovery in 1924.
- Dholavira was made a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2021.